MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 3: Poetry (Non-detailed Study)

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Sidney, Herbert, and Marvell use poetry to explore writing, spiritual recovery, and the pressure of passing time.

Start with a picture

Three people are trying to explain a feeling. One searches for the right words, one draws wings, and one argues with a ticking clock. Those pictures help us enter the three poems.

1. Sidney: Astrophil and Stella, Sonnet 1

What happens?

Astrophil wants Stella to understand his love. He hopes his writing will give her pleasure, make her read, help her understand his suffering, awaken pity, and eventually win affection.

He studies other writers and struggles to find impressive language. His effort becomes frustrating. At the end, the Muse tells him to look into his own heart and write.

Explain it simply

Imagine making a birthday card. You copy clever lines from several cards, but none expresses what you feel. Finally, you write a plain, personal sentence. Sidney explores a related problem: how can a poem sound sincere while using inherited poetic forms?

This is not proof that poetry needs no skill. The sonnet itself is carefully made. It stages a tension between learning from others and finding an individual voice.

Important details

- **Astrophil:** the lover-speaker; the name suggests a star-lover.
- **Stella:** the beloved; her name means star.
- **Muse:** a figure of artistic inspiration.
- **Sonnet:** fourteen lines; this poem uses the rhyme pattern ABAB ABAB CDCD EE.
- **Metre:** unusually, its lines are generally twelve-syllable alexandrines rather than the ten-syllable line often expected in English sonnets.

The speaker is a literary character. Do not assume every statement is a direct diary entry by Sidney.

2. Herbert: Easter Wings

What happens?

The speaker remembers humanity’s fall from an originally richer condition and his own weakness. He asks God to help him rise through spiritual connection with Christ.

Why does it look like wings?

The lines become shorter and then longer. Shortening suggests loss, weakness, and contraction; widening suggests renewal and rising. The visual shape participates in the meaning. This is a **pattern poem** or **shaped poem**.

Imagine drawing a bird with folded wings, then opening them. Herbert makes the reader see something like that movement while reading about spiritual renewal.

Important ideas

Easter connects the poem to Christ’s resurrection. The movement from falling to rising expresses dependence on divine grace. The image of **imping**, repairing a bird’s damaged wing by adding feathers, develops the idea of strength gained through attachment to another.

Weakness becomes the occasion for help and transformation, rather than the final word about the speaker.

3. Marvell: To His Coy Mistress

What happens?

A speaker tries to persuade a reluctant beloved to accept physical love. He builds a three-part argument:

1. **If we had unlimited time:** slow courtship would be possible.
2. **But time and death are real:** human lives are short.
3. **Therefore:** he urges them to act now.

This is a **carpe diem** argument: “seize the day.” It uses extravagant praise, startling images of death, and energetic images of desire.

Read the argument critically

Imagine an advertisement saying, “This chance ends today, so decide now.” Urgency can persuade, but it can also pressure someone. Ask whether the poem’s speaker is reasoning fairly, manipulating fear, or doing both.

The speaker’s argument is not automatically the poet’s personal belief, and the poem gives no clear spoken answer from the beloved. Her consent must not be assumed.

Compare the poems

Poem	Central difficulty	Main technique
Sonnet 1	Finding persuasive, sincere language	A staged struggle ending in a turn
Easter Wings	Human and personal weakness	Shape and Christian imagery
To His Coy Mistress	Desire under the pressure of time	A conditional argument and hyperbole

Quick check

1. Where is Astrophil finally told to look? **Into his own heart.**
2. Why do Herbert’s line lengths matter? **The form enacts decline and renewal.**
3. Does Marvell’s beloved clearly agree? **No; the reader hears the speaker’s persuasion, not an explicit reply.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Explain how poetic form and argument shape the three selected poems.

Expanded discussion

Sidney’s first sonnet in Astrophil and Stella dramatises the act of composition itself. The speaker wants writing to produce a sequence of effects in the beloved, moving from pleasure and reading towards understanding, pity, and affection. His search for language among other writers becomes frustrating, and the final instruction to look into his heart creates a turn in the argument. Nevertheless, the apparent appeal to simplicity is achieved through a carefully organised poem. Sincerity and literary craftsmanship are placed in tension rather than made into opposites.

Herbert’s Easter Wings makes formal arrangement visible. The shortening and lengthening lines give the reader an experience of contraction and expansion corresponding to spiritual decline and recovery. The poem’s Christian framework connects human weakness with the possibility of renewal through divine grace. Its shape is therefore an active part of the argument. Describing it merely as an attractive picture would miss the relation between bodily form, emotional movement, and devotional meaning.

Marvell’s To His Coy Mistress relies on a conditional structure: unlimited time would permit leisurely courtship, but mortality makes delay appear dangerous, so the speaker urges immediate fulfilment. Hyperbole and images of death strengthen the emotional pressure of this reasoning. A critical reader should examine its persuasive force without confusing persuasion with consent. The beloved does not deliver a clear answer. Comparing these poems shows how a sonnet’s turn, a shaped poem’s visual design, and an argumentative sequence can each organise feeling in a different way.

Suggested answer structure

1. State each speaker’s problem
2. Sidney: persuasion and poetic creation
3. Herbert: shape and spiritual movement
4. Marvell: if, but, therefore
5. Compare how form directs the reader

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not confuse Sidney’s speaker with an unmediated diary voice. In Marvell, analyse the speaker’s pressure without assuming the beloved agrees.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.